

The Accursed Share of Non-fungibles

What NFTs and Blockchains Suggest for Arts Practice, Pedagogy, and the General Economy

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ABSTRACT

As described by Georges Bataille in his 1949 essays on General Economy, *the Accursed Share* refers to the excessive and non-recuperable portions of an economy that must be spent lavishly or luxuriously, or otherwise be destined to outrageous, destructive, and catastrophic expressions — most often resulting in war, or other ruinous and destructive acts [Bataille and Hurley 1988]. How might we might consider Bataille's idea as expressed through the recent boom in Non-Fungible Tokens (NFTs) and contemporary Blockchain technology? Between 2020 and 2021, the global trading volume of NFTs increased ten-fold [Nadini et al., 2021], with a reported global market of 22 billion USD in 2021 [Milmo 2021]. Researchers Matthieu Nadini (et al.) note that digital art sales accounted for roughly 10 percent of all NFT transactions in 2021 [Nadini et al., 2021]. The volume and frequency of the booming NFT market cannot be ignored, but what does it suggest for the future of art practice and pedagogy, and how does it relate to the excesses suggested in Bataille's notion of general economy?

A panel of artists and NFT pioneers demystify NFTs, discussing the virtues and vices of such radical shifts in art-commerce. Panelists expose the process of making and selling NFTs, the ecological and pedagogical impacts of blockchain technologies, and speculate on future outlooks for digital art practice. Discussion provides critical reflection on the philosophical and cultural implications that accompany shifts into evermore virtualized art-experiences. Questions considered include what import does Bataille's seminal text bear in relation to contemporary digital art practice; what are the tangible cultural and ecological effects of digital art practice; and what insights does Bataille's notion of general economy hold for the experience of contemporary art and future art practice. Discussion will expose fresh outlooks on possible futures of art practice and pedagogy, as related to the fields of computer graphics and interactive techniques.

CCS CONCEPTS

• **Applied computing** → Arts and humanities; Media arts; Arts and humanities; Fine arts; Education; • **General and reference** → Cross-computing tools and techniques; Cross-computing tools and techniques; Design; Cross-computing tools and techniques; Experimentation; • **Social and professional topics** → Professional topics; Computing profession; • **Additional Keywords and Phrases:** **Non-Fungible Tokens, Blockchain, Digital Art Economies;**

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1 PANELISTS

Johannes DeYoung (moderator) is an artist and educator who works at the intersection of computational and material processes. His moving-image works are exhibited internationally in galleries and museums in countries such as Australia, Brazil, Canada, Germany, Ireland, Spain, Taiwan, and the USA, as well as being featured in The New York Times, The New York Post, The Huffington Post, and Dossier Journal. He is Assistant Professor of Electronic and Time-Based Media at Carnegie Mellon University. He previously taught at Yale University School of Art (2008–2018), where he was appointed Senior Critic and Director of the Center for Collaborative Arts and Media.

Dr. Melentie Pandilovski is an art theorist, historian, writer, and Executive Director of Experimenta, Australia's leading organization dedicated to commissioning, exhibiting and touring contemporary art driven by technology. He has over twenty-five years of experience working in the arts in Australia and internationally. Prior to Experimenta, he served as Director of the Riddoch Art Gallery and Manager of Arts and Cultural Development at the City of Mount Gambier; he was Director of Video Pool Media Arts Centre in Winnipeg, Canada (2011–16); Director of the Visual Cultural Research Centre, Euro-Balkan Institute in Skopje, Macedonia (2009–11); Director of the Experimental Art Foundation in Adelaide, Australia (2003–2009), and the Contemporary Arts Centre in Skopje, Macedonia (1998–2003). He has organized and curated more than 200

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projects including exhibitions, symposia, conferences and workshops, in Europe, Australia, Canada, and the U.S.

Brainard Carey is an artist, educator, and cofounder of the artistic collaborative Praxis with his wife, Delia Carey. Praxis has been included in venues such as The Whitney Museum of American Art biennial, as well as the Museum of Modern Art and other exhibitions / biennials throughout the world. As host of the popular Yale University radio show, *Lives of the Artists*, he has interviewed over 1,500 artists and creative people to illuminate their careers and work. He has authored several books on professional development for artists, the most recent being, *Making it in the Art World* (2021, Allworth Press).

Federico Solmi is a new media artist, born in Bologna, Italy in 1973. In 2009, Solmi was awarded by the John Simon Guggenheim Memorial Fellowship in the category of Video & Audio. His work is exhibited internationally in numerous prestigious venues such as

The Phillips Collection; the Smithsonian National Portrait Gallery; *Open Spaces: A Kansas City Arts Experience* (2018); the *Beijing Media Art Biennale* (2016); *Frankfurt B3 Biennial of the Moving image* (2017-2015); the *First Shenzhen Animation Biennial in China* (2013); the *54th Venice Biennial* (2011); and *SITE Santa Fe Biennial in New Mexico* (2010). From 2016 to 2019 Federico Solmi served as adjunct faculty at Yale University School of Art and Yale School of Drama, in New Haven, CT.

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